port of stressed patients. "If someone is passively responding to stress, holding in all their emotions and not actively doing something about the situation, then they have more chances of letting that stress affect their mind and body," says Dr Malhotra. "Those who are mindfully and actively overcoming stress have the opposite impact."

Simultaneously, research is also shedding new light on ways to manage stress. No longer are medicines and therapy the only, or even the first, answer. Even a virtual nature walk can significantly mitigate reported stress levels, according to a pilot study published in *PLOS One* in February 2022. From crystal healing to meditation, *pranayama* to walking, building your social system to journal-keeping, gardening to doing jigsaw puzzles—different and innovative techniques can now help you relax. Relaxation, in turn, leads to mindfulness, a cognitive process essential to cope with stress. Practising mindfulness influences two stress pathways in the brain, altering the brain structure and activity in regions that regulate attention and emotion, according to the American Psychological Association. So, when faced with a trigger or challenging situation, the brain looks for solutions rather than locking into an automated stress response.



"To beat stress, one needs to **cognitively rewire** oneself by relaxing with a different activity. Stress then becomes not a threat but just another situation"

–DR UPASANA CHADDHA-VIJ, *Counselling Psychologist, Delhi*

When you relax and start to engage your brain with a different activity, over time, you stop thinking of stress as a threat but as just another situation," says Delhi-based psychologist Dr Upasana Chaddha-Vij. "We are realising more and more that people need to have moment-to-moment awareness or mindfulness." Doctors say one has to detach from the stress itself in order to respond to it. This is because the more you think of stress, the more your body releases stress hormones. "Stress hormones overshadow everything else," adds Chaddha-Vij. "You get that sinking feeling in your stomach and find that your brain is unable to find rational solutions. When you are relaxed, the opposite happens." Indeed, a randomised trial published in the journal *Brain, Behavior, & Immunity - Health* in May 2022 found that mindfulness-increasing activities actually led to reduction in perceived stress as well as lower inflammatory markers in the body.

Doctors also say that a little bit of stress is good for you. Positive stress, or eustress, the opposite of distress, is healthy, and can keep the body's response system running. Different people also react to stress differently, depending on their personality type, support system and a positive mindset. Coping mechanisms, too, vary from person to person. There is no such thing as a stress-free life. "You can't have no stress," says Dr Seth. "What you can do is reduce the impact stress has on your body and mind." All exercises—whether spiritual, emotional or physical—train the mind to relax and think with more awareness. A 2022 study of 73 adults by the University of Innsbruck in Austria found that those who meditate could resist the urge to check their phones as soon as they got a notification. For Neha Kapur, a 39-year-old homemaker from Pune, the same change has happened thanks to gardening. "I go into a meditative trance when I am with plants," she says. "And I realise that I am no longer drawn to that which gives me anxiety." It has also helped ease the young professional's blood pressure and migraine attacks. Anand Datta, 42, an engineer from Kolkata, says he gets the same benefit from keeping a journal or listening to the piano every time he finds himself overthinking. "The idea is to cognitively rewire yourself into relaxing every time you feel stressed," says Dr Chaddha-Vij. "People find different things relaxing." Even if some might dismiss them as a pseudo-science.

Negi, for instance, finds crystal healing to be the answer to her stress attacks. She has placed a gigantic black tourmaline pyramid in front of the main door in their house, and meditates with a smaller version every morning. She follows it up with eating two pieces of chocolate in silence. On particularly bad days, she also relaxes by rubbing dried lavender all over her face. All this has not only helped her ease the neck pain that had her in agony, but also given her better sleep, improved appetite and more energy. "In three months, my body feels lighter—almost younger," she says. She and her husband are also having fewer disagreements than before.

For those who face moderate stress, experts strongly recommend *pranayama* or meditation to improve mindfulness. With their experiment, reported this year in the peer-reviewed